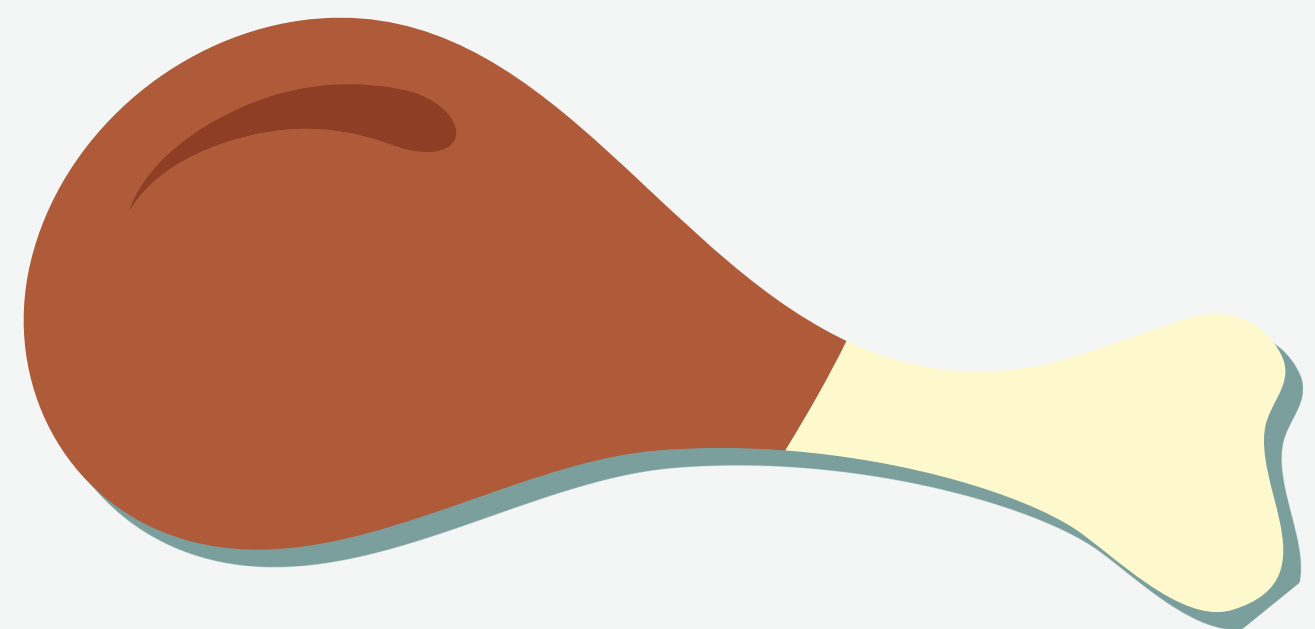




זְרוֹעַ

Ze-ro-ah

Shank Bone



A roasted chicken bone, stripped of meat, for display only. On the evening before leaving Egypt, in defiance of their masters, the Jews offered up a sheep – an Egyptian deity -- as the Paschal sacrifice. In commemoration, the special Paschal sacrifice was offered in the Holy Temple on the eve of Passover each year. In the absence of the Holy Temple, we use a chicken bone to distinguish this item from an actual sacrifice.

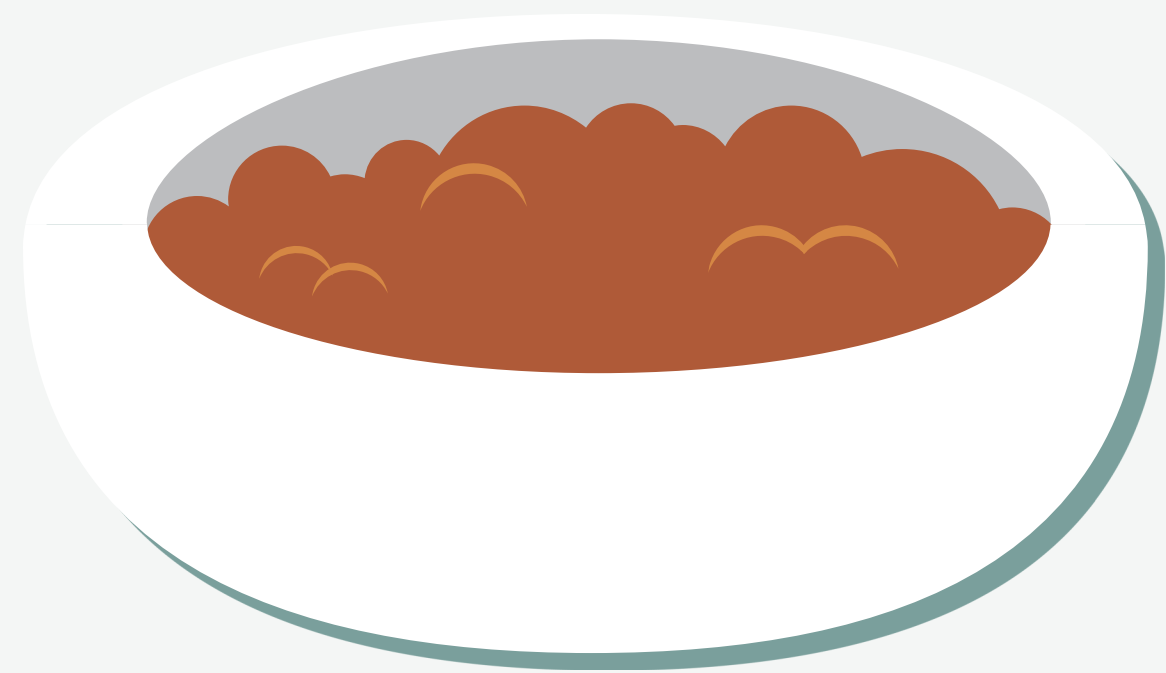




חרוסת

Cha-ro-set

Paste



A paste made of apples, pears, nuts and wine, to be used as a dip for the bitter herbs. Charoset has the appearance and texture of the river mud from which our ancestors made bricks. It represents the harsh servitude our ancestors experienced as slaves. But its taste is sweet, representing our present-day freedom.





חזרת

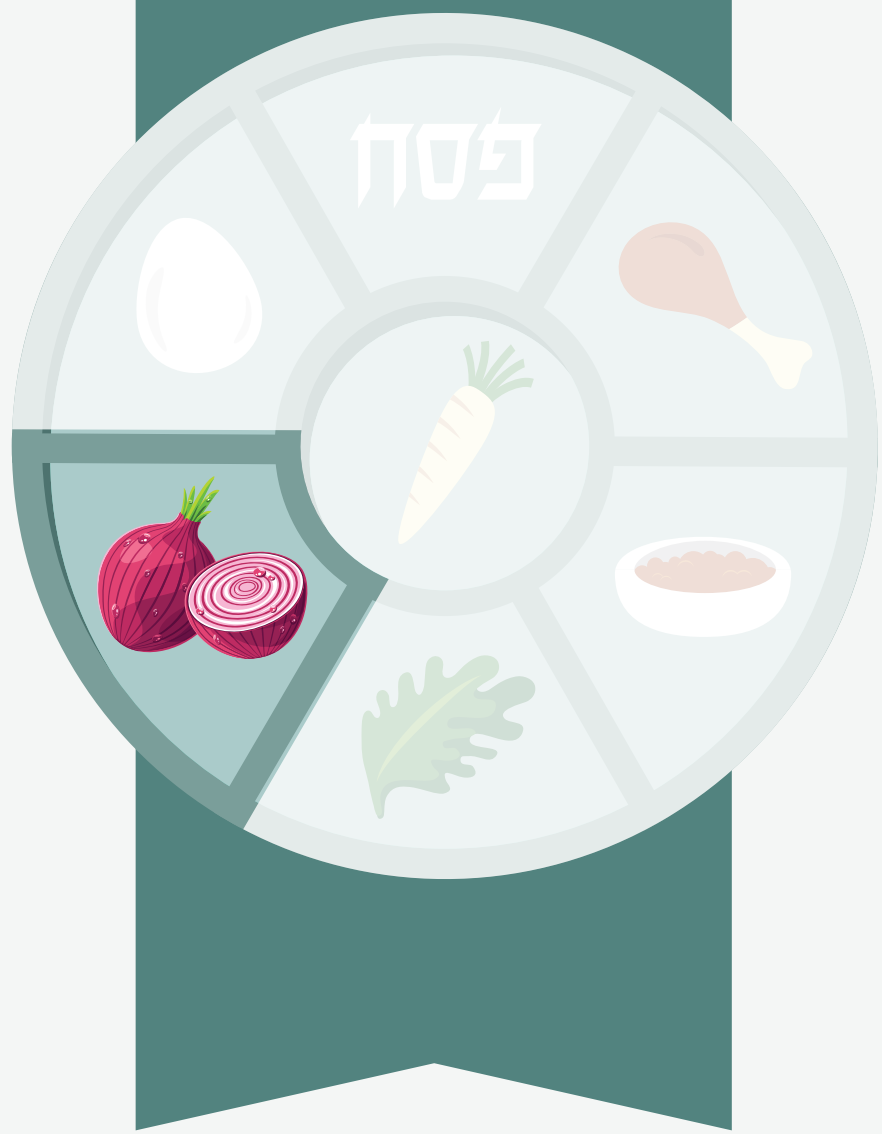
Cha-zē-ret

More Bitter Herbs



The ground horseradish is wrapped in a bed of lettuce. The lettuce is an important symbol, as its sweet leaves – representing freedom -- grow from a bitter stalk (representing slavery). Freedom is most appreciated when it emerges from slavery. We who are born free often take our freedom for granted. Yet the Seder rituals remind us that we were once slaves, allowing us to appreciate our freedom more deeply.

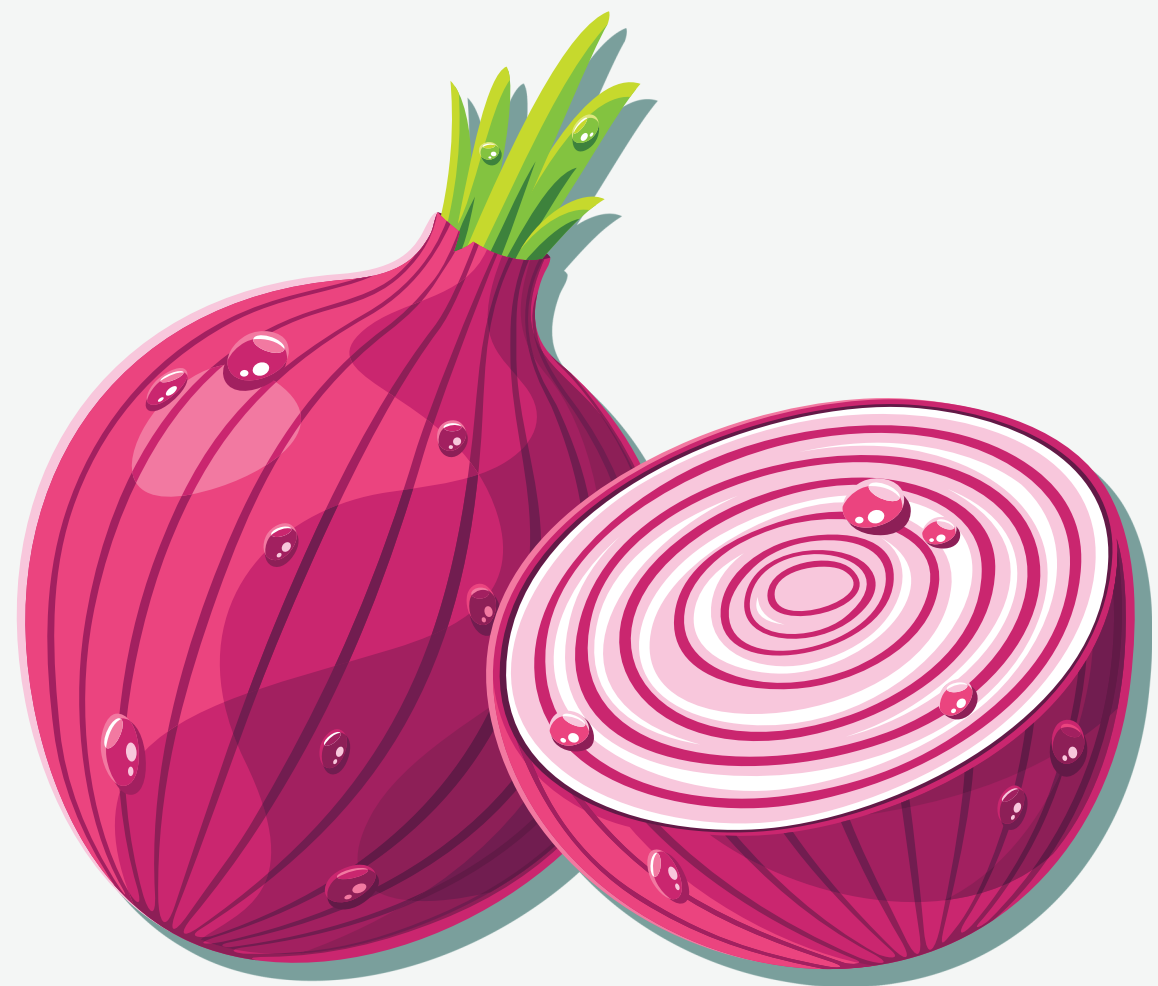




כַּרְפָּס

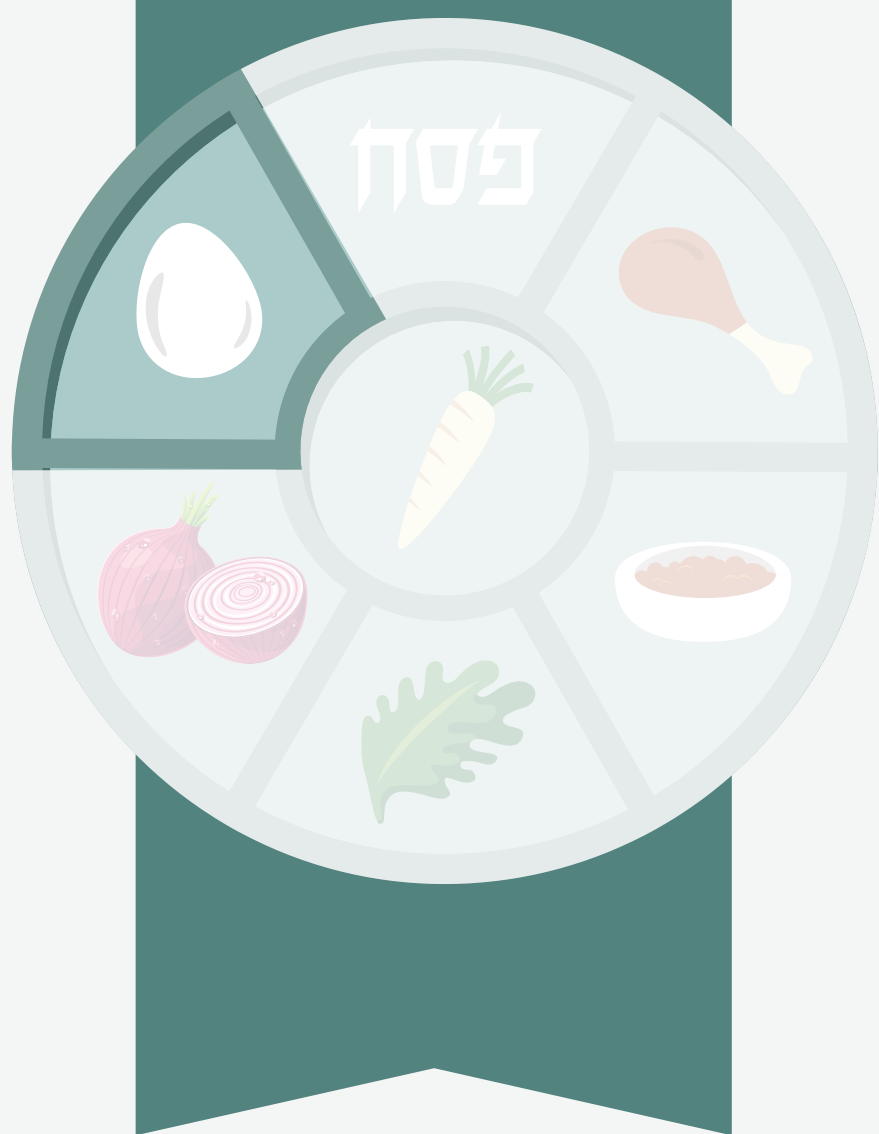
Kar-pās

Vegetable



The Hebrew word for “greens” or “vegetable,” usually represented as a piece of onion or potato that we will later dip into salt water. Karpas read backwards forms an acronym of the phrase: “600,000 [were enslaved with] spirit-breaking labor,” and the salt water in which it is dipped represents the tears they shed. We re-taste our slavery with gratitude, knowing that our labor prepared us for freedom and the humility to accept Torah wisdom.





ביצה

Bei-tzah

Egg



A hard-boiled egg, calling to mind the Holy Temple where our ancestors used to offer the holiday sacrifice. It is characteristic of Jewish celebrations that there should be something to bring the Holy Temple to mind. The egg represents the festive sacrifice which was offered on the three pilgrim festivals, Passover, Shavuot and Sukkot.





מרור

Ma-ror

Bitter Herbs



The bitter herbs remind us of how the Egyptians embittered our lives. We choose to remember our bitterness because it was the key to our redemption. Tradition tells us that 80% of the Jews said, "This is our land. How can we leave it?" when Moses tried to rally them for flight. They stayed and died there. But the rest of us, who could not resign ourselves to slavery in Egypt, heeded Moses' call and followed him. We each have our "personal Egypt". Bitterness alone will not liberate us. But the desire for better, along with energy and faith, is the springboard to freedom.

